Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Joe Wilder
Part II

Joe Wilder was born in Pennsylvania on February 22, 1922, and he was raised in Philadelphia. His classmates at the Mastbaum School of Music were Buddy DeFranco and Red Rodney. His trumpet playing has been heard with Les Hite, Lionel Hampton, Jimmy Lunceford and Count Basie, as well as in the pit orchestras of New York and he has been called on to perform in the New York Philharmonic and the Smithsonian Jazz Repertory Orchestra. He is a highly respected musician for his skill in ensembles and for his personal jazz phrasing. His most recent album is entitled "No Greater Love."

Joe was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, in Clinton, NY on October 12, 1998.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, and I'm very pleased to have a second conversation with Joe Wilder. Welcome.

JW: Thank you.

MR: You saw some great photo opportunities already this morning.

JW: Oh did we ever, a couple of good ones I hope, anyway.

MR: It's quite a passion of yours.

JW: It is actually.

MR: Have you been doing it for a lot of years?

JW: Well I started doing it as a hobby actually when I was in the Marine Corps, that's a long time ago, 1944. And I've sort of stuck with it since then. It's interesting. It gives you a chance to be a little creative.

MR: And I know you like to send photos back to people.

JW: Yeah, I do that because usually you have no way of expressing your appreciation to the people you've worked for, the people you've been associated with, and it gives you a chance to give something back to them. I mean a lot of people are very wealthy. I'm not wealthy enough to match that, and so people seem to appreciate photographs and things like that. And a lot of times I make a point of trying to take pictures of people with their families in situations where maybe ordinarily they wouldn't get a picture of the family. And it's something that they can recall, that particular period of their lives, and it's nice for them.

MR: The first time we talked we were down in Sarasota. You were playing a jazz festival. And we didn't get to a couple of things that I'd like to talk a little bit about today if we could. And you mentioned the Marines. You were drafted?

JW: Yes.

MR: And what year was that?

JW: 1943.

MR: Did you feel that you were going to be sent overseas at that point?

JW: That's one of the reasons I went into the Marine Corps. I had a choice of going into the Army, the Navy or the Marine Corps, which had just begun to recruit black marines. This was the first time. I was not in the initial group, but the platoon that I was in brought the number of black marines to ten hundred. And so I was given a choice, do you want to go in the Army, the Navy or the Marine Corps. And they said they're not accepting any more non-combatants. And so, to go into the music thing, there was no possibility at that time in either of them, at least that's what I was told. So I said well if it's going to be a combat thing I might as well go into the Marine Corps, they were supposed to train people for that. And that's where I went.

MR: But you did get to play in the band?

JW: I did eventually. I was in a unit that was being trained for small weapons, a unit. And Bobby Troup, who was a lieutenant at that time, he knew that I was a musician and he finally said that you might as well add him to the band. And I was transferred after boot camp to the band, and later on I became the assistant bandmaster of the band.

MR: You had to play for marches and assemblies and all that kind of thing?

JW: All those things. And for instance one thing I remember very well, we were playing for a general whose name was Chesty Puller. He was one of the most famous of the Marine generals. And he was giving a medal of honor I think to some Marine who had earned that, and we played for that ceremony, and I remember that. And there were certain procedures you go through when you go up and salute the general and he throws the salute back and when I executed all these things that I was supposed to do and I heard him say "that's my kind of Marine." So it was a real compliment.

MR: Nice. Did you play dance music also for the base?

JW: Oh yes, we had a dance orchestra, we had a dance band, and we played at the officer's club on weekends and we played sometimes at the USO. And that's basically what they did with the dance band.

MR: Was there a period of adjustment or any unpleasantness in the fact that the Marines had just become integrated?

JW: Yeah, it was rough in the beginning. It was a pretty rough situation because there were no black officers and there were only a few black non-commissioned officers, corporals and maybe a couple of buck sergeants. But that came later actually. So that all the personnel with any authority were white, all the personnel. And of course we were in the middle of the south, so conditions were based on the racial problems that we had prior to that, and of course in the military it was a lot more severe.

MR: You had told me about an incident with one of the bands you were with in the south, I think it was South Carolina?

JW: Oh, Lucky Millinder, yeah.

MR: Yes. And it was the first time you'd been down there with an integrated band?

JW: Yeah. We were in South Carolina. And Lucky Millinder, Lucky was a very nice fellow. He was not a musician, but he had a lot of natural talent for selecting the right kinds of tunes and tempos and things of that nature. But we had — I think six of the members of the band were white. And we arrived early in South Carolina at this hall where we were going to play, and suddenly up drove the sheriff with his deputy in the police car, and he says, "who's in charge here?" And so Lucky said, "I am." He said, "well I'm just here to tell you there's not going to be any mixed bands playing down here in Charleston." And Lucky looked at this guy, and Lucky — you know the reason I think they called him Lucky, he would take a chance on anything — he looked this guy dead in the eye and said, "this is not a mixed band." And some of the guys were blonde with blue eyes you know, there was no way in the world anybody would have mistaken any of these guys for being black you know. And so he went to each guy. I think if he had said, "are you Black?" he might have gotten a different answer. But he went to each of these guys and asked, he said, "are you colored?" And each of the guys, going along with what Lucky had said, would say yes. And so he would shake his head. And finally the last of the guys he asked was Porky Cohen, who was our first trombone player. And he had a slight lisp. And when he asked him, now Porky is responding more emphatically than the other guys, and he said, "why thertainly" with this lisp. And at this point we had all been starting to chew on our tongues and everything, trying not to break up because it was so ludicrous. And when he did this you could almost feel the ground tremble, with the guys laughing and we were trying not to let the sheriff see it. But anyway he turned to the deputy and he said, "well I guess if they all say they're colored, there ain't nothing we can do about it, is there, Jeff?" And so he said, "no sheriff." And they got in the car and drove off. And we played that dance that night. It was very funny. And it might, as I mentioned to you, it might have been the first time that an integrated band played there. It's very possible that that was the first time.

MR: Do you think Lucky was anticipating any problems going down there, but he just said well we're going to do it anyway?

JW: Well Lucky knew that there were some problems, but he was a guy that it just didn't matter to him, it didn't make any difference. Once he got there he would try to take care of whatever came up, and he was fortunate that usually he handled it very well.

MR: And this was before or after the Marines?

JW: This was after.

MR: Oh. The late forties?

JW: It was 1948.

MR: Wow. You've been on the forefront of a number of times of integrating things, in the studios in New York too?

JW: Right, right, right. I was with Jimmy Lunceford at the time of his death. And when I came back I came back to New York and I went back to Philadelphia actually. And I stayed there for just a short time, then I joined Herbie Fields' band. And he had had an integrated band on several occasions. It was a small group. But Frank Rosolino was in the band when I was there, and Rudy Cafaro was playing guitar, and Joe Gatto was playing piano. And we had really a nice group. Then after I left that band I went with Sam Donahue, and I was the only black musician in that band at that time. It was a nice band, a nice bunch of fellows.

MR: I wanted to ask you again, I brought it up the last time, but in watching you operate, you've been here for a few days on the campus and you seem to have a very well formed work ethic, as I'm going to call it. And you had told me about a few things that you believe are right in the way you operate your business and deal with other people. And I'm wondering, where did you get this work ethic? Was it something from your family?

JW: I guess I got it mainly from my father, who was a musician. My father played with a lot of the bands in Philadelphia and he was a stickler for being on time. He used to pound that into my brothers and me. You know it's better for you to come one hour early than to come one second late for something, and he would use as an example, there was a drummer that played with one of the bands he played with. And the guy was a good drummer. And he said, "you know the dance starts at eight o'clock and we're all there," and he said "and we're all sitting on the bandstand ready to play and the drummer isn't there. He comes at eight fifteen." He said, "he knows it takes him at least 20 minutes to set up his drums." He said, "now what sense does that make? What excuse is that?" And then he would say, "you know just because you're black doesn't mean you have to show up late." And they had an expression that they used to use, they would say you go to work and you come on time, and then there's another time that they call "CP time" — colored people's time — CPT was a thing they used to use. The blacks used it in reference to the other people that came late you see? And they would say well there is such a thing as the correct time and CPT, colored people's time. So this was a real put down, so you didn't want to get involved with that. But that's basically where I got it from, my father. And the other idea, the deportment of the guys on the job and things like that. He felt that they had an obligation to come on time, perform properly, to dress properly and conduct themselves in a way that people wouldn't have any problems with them you know.

MR: I've never heard that expression.

JW: Yeah, it's an old expression. A lot of the Latino musicians have an expression that's similar too. The Latino musicians, one fellow was a friend of mine and he was one of the first Latin musicians to play in the Broadway theaters. And we were doing "Lorelei" with Carol Channing. And a couple of times he showed up, the show hits at two o'clock, and at two thirty he came in and he couldn't walk through the band, he had a crawl because of the way we were all set up, he had to crawl through the orchestra to get to his seat. And he was so accustomed to showing up late when he'd play a Latin dance some place in some hall, if he got there a half hour late, as long as you got there it was okay. So they had to explain to him that this is not a Latin dance hall, it was a Broadway theater.

MR: I've wondered that, because I've worked with a couple of Latin musicians who had the same kind of attitude, and I wonder if there's a cultural — that they're basically more relaxed people in their daily lives.

JW: That's basically what it is. It has nothing to do with the character, it's just that that's the way things are. You know when the party starts at two, it's going to go until ten anyway so if you get there sometime in between it's okay.

MR: My goodness. We talked a bit about ABC and those must have been pretty busy days for you.

JW: They were. They were pretty busy days for almost all the musicians in New York.

MR: That whole thing with the orchestras, what was the era that that ran from?

JW: I would think, well I guess it went from about the late 30's through the 70's. Because I think it was '75 when we stopped doing the Dick Cavett show, and at that point they had begun to get rid of the staff orchestras at all the networks.

MR: They had some fairly well known classical people head up those orchestras, didn't they?

JW: Right. Well at NBC they got Toscannini. At CBS Paul Lavalle had the City Services Concert band, and at ABC very often we had Arthur Fiedler. And we had others, because they did the Metropolitan Opera auditions on the air, and they did "Music for a Summer Night" and "Voice of Firestone," and they would very often have guest conductors come in for those things.

MR: Was most of the music you recorded in those orchestra situations, was it going on tape for use later? Or was it live?

JW: No it was live. Almost all of it was live. And a lot of it they recorded. And when they finally got rid of the staffs, all these tapes and things they had, they just threw them in the garbage. I mean a lot of them just went in the trash. And there were a couple of fellows who were involved with ABC with the library there, who had the good sense to take some of this stuff, knowing that they were just going to throw it out. And they were able to save some of it. But the bulk of it was just thrown out. And some of the libraries that

they had, I think they gave some of it to Columbia University or Princeton or something, and some of it was given to one of the colleges, but most of it they just threw out because it was in the way.

MR: I'm going to return to your work ethic again — it must have served you pretty well in this situation, because it obviously had to be, there's no crawling into the section a half hour late.

JW: No, no, no. If you did these things it was a matter of just routine. And everybody complied. There was nothing servile about it, it was just that this was the job to do and these are the requirements for doing it.

MR: When was the first opportunity to get with a major label, under your own name?

JW: That was when I did an album called "The Pretty Sound" for Columbia. And Nat Shapiro, that's who — I couldn't think of Nat's name — he's the one who promoted me, I mean for that record and for "Peter Gunn." He was responsible for that. But that was the first time. I did some things for Savoy, but nothing, as far as I'm concerned, of the quality of the Columbia things.

MR: Well I noticed in looking, this was recorded it says January 18, 1959. So you had one day to do ten songs.

JW: We did the whole thing in one session, that's right.

MR: Wow.

JW: It took us probably two sessions involved, but it was the same day.

MR: Right. They do three hour sessions? That's what I've been hearing from other folks.

JW: Oh yeah.

MR: And they like you to avoid the overtime, don't they?

JW: Oh did they ever.

MR: Well you said you hadn't read these liner notes —

JW: No I haven't.

MR: — and I just wanted to — I could read anything and you wouldn't know it. It says, "Joe Wilder is blessed with impeccable taste, penetrating intelligence and the most beautiful horn tone since the great Joe Smith blew his heavenly sounds in Fletcher Henderson's band."

JW: Well that's a nice compliment.

MR: Isn't that nice? "British critics said he's one of the very few completely fresh and original trumpet stylists to emerge with modern jazz." Not bad.

JW: That's a nice thing.

MR: So I'm out today to find out the secret of Joe Wilder's tone, so I can sell the information.

JW: You know I studied with a teacher, I had a very fine teacher and everything. I had a couple of teachers prior to him, they were friends of my father's, and one, what was his

name, Chauncy Welsh was a saxophone player with Cab Calloway's band — not Chauncy Welsh, Chauncy Hartley. And he had a brother, Cliff Hartley, who was a very good trumpet player. And he lived in Baltimore but he used to come to Philadelphia. And I studied with him for a while, only a short time. And then my father decided that I should study with a man named Fred Griffin, who was a cornet soloist. He played these same kinds of solos as Del Staigers and Herbert Clarke and these people. And I studied with him. And he was a stickler for sound on the instrument, that you had to get a big sound on the instrument. He stressed that and technique. And he had taught my father. My father played sousaphone, he played cornet in the beginning, and he studied with Mr. Griffin, and then he switched to sousaphone and Griffin taught piano, trumpet, trombone and almost all the brass instruments. And so I studied with him, and he was one of these teachers that when you'd play out of the Arban book we were using, and he knew this thing inside out. And he'd say and he'd tell you what exercise to play, and you'd play it, and he'd say "that's not a C, that was an E flat" or something. That's what the note is. And he'd literally beat it into me. But that's where it comes from.

MR: You got some discipline out of that I would imagine.

JW: He was a tremendous player though, because at one of the radio stations, I think it was WPEN or WCAU, I'm not sure which it was, but at any rate, they would have a period during which they had no scheduling of any commercial thing or something, and they'd just have a time slot that they had nothing to fill it in with, and they would call him and there was a pianist named Franklin Haweksberry, and he was a concert pianist, and he would accompany Fred Griffin on these cornet solos, and the network would call and say we need you for an hour or a half hour to play cornet solos to fill in the spot, and that's what he did. He was a really fine player.

MR: That's interesting. Those days are pretty much gone of someone coming in and playing live for an hour.

JW: Right.

MR: I wanted to ask you about when you were with the couple of big bands before the Marines, and then after again, can you recall if you had a goal? An eventual goal for your music career at that point?

JW: You know I was so thrilled in a way and surprised too that I ended up for instance in Les Hite's band because I was 19 years old and this was quite an experience for me, and I remember when I left Philadelphia on a bus to go to Lansing, Michigan to join Les Hite's band and my mother accompanied me to the bus terminal, and I can remember my mother standing, as I had the window down and the bus is loaded with people, and my mother saying, "don't you do anything to embarrass this family while you're away." And I said "okay mother." But I remember that moment when I was leaving Philly. But I was

rather surprised and I was actually in awe of most of the fellows who were in those bands. They were a little older than me. Some of them were in my age group but a lot of them were older and had a lot more experience. So I felt kind of lucky to be there. When I left Les Hite I joined the Lionel Hampton band, which at that time was roaring, and I was really in awe of that band. I mean I was again quite happy that I became a member. But it's strange because the first trumpet player was Carl George and he was getting a divorce or something, and he had to go to St. Louis for this legal thing. And they needed someone to come in and play just during the period that he was away. And so somebody recommended me and I left Les Hite's band and joined that band. And while we were there it was Ernie Royal, Joe Newman and I were the trumpets. And then when Carl came back they decided to keep four trumpets. And that's how I remained with the band. So I stayed with them until I went into the service.

MR: It wasn't the easiest gig in the world, from what I understand.

JW: It wasn't, no it wasn't. There were many times when it wasn't. And the funny thing of it is that my antagonism towards Lionel didn't come from anything he did to me personally, it was things that they did to other people that you were witness to you know. For instance the bass player, Vernon Alley, a very fine bass player, he became ill. We were someplace in Texas. And the doctor said he had the flu or something and he has to stay in bed for at least a week. And so it was like okay, they gave him the money that he had earned, we had played like maybe four days of that week, so they gave him salary for the four days and a ticket back — nothing extra — and a ticket back to California, a one way ticket, so he could go back home after he recuperated, and he just hired another bass player. He comes back, okay, you're sick, goodbye. And things like that. It used to really get to me. I thought it was so mean and that's one of the milder things.

MR: Were you aspiring to play in a classical situation at that time also?

JW: Well yes I did, and even while I was with the band I always practiced a lot of classical things, not thinking that I would ever get an opportunity to play in a symphony orchestra, but I just did it because of my interest in that. And when I was younger I heard Del Staigers , who, he's one, and I'm sure I heard Herbert Clarke and Walter Smith, people like that who were very famous cornet soloists. But I remember Del Staigers for some reason or other better than the others, and I always wanted to play like Del Staigers . He could double tongue and triple tongue and all this. And apropos of that, Dick Perry, who was the first trumpet player with "Lorelei," he was playing first trumpet, that's how it was, and he knew, I had mentioned several times that I liked Del Staigers . So one day he says "you know I have two recordings of Del Staigers." And he said "they're in a double album thing." And he said "one day I'll bring it in and you can take it home and you can put it on a cassette and record it, and then bring them back to me." So I said "okay." And

he did that. He brought them in. So I took it home and it was Del Staigers , and he had a very high pitched voice "and now when you do this —" you do so and so and so and so. He had a voice like that. But his playing was really beautiful. And of course the recording wasn't that great because of the time at which it was done. So I thought to myself, now what can I do to put Dick Perry on when I go back with these recordings? And I had one of these big LP's on rubber about that thick, those old recordings, it was of no use. And I took this thing and threw it on the floor, and it ended up in about 50 small pieces you know, and I put these in this envelope with his recording, the two recordings. So when I came into the theater I was coming and I saw him and some of the other guys and I nudged one of the other fellows coming in and I said, "watch this." And I pretended I stumbled on the stairs, and as I did I turned this envelope and these pieces are falling out of the envelope on the floor. And I said, "oh my God, Dick, I'm so sorry," I said, "I just dropped the records," and I said, "look at this." And Pete said he's sitting there and he's almost like almost pale. Finally he said, "well, you did put it on cassette didn't you?" I said, "yeah I did record it." And then I started laughing, I started smiling. He looked at me and he said "you know what?" He said, "I know what it is, you're up to one of your dirty tricks." I just broke up. I mean if you could have seen the expression on his face when this manila envelope turned out these pieces falling all over.

MR: Yeah, I've learned that you're quite a practical joker. Bob Rosengarden was saying, he called them "Wilderisms" that you used to do on the Dick Cavett band?

JW: Oh yeah. I was always — you know the pages would ask the audience to write questions or some comment, make a comment about something. So he said, "why don't you write something?" So I wrote a thing — I had been doing research on the Salem witch trials, and I discovered that during that period there were two sisters who were also burned at the stake — the Kendall sisters — and one was Mary and the other one was Susan Kendall. And it just turns out by coincidence that Mary Kendall was the first woman who burned at the stake, and Susan was the last one. And I said that's where we got the expression "burning the Kendalls at both ends." Dick Cavett was looking at this, and he got just almost to that point, and he said, "I know where this is going, who did this?" The guys started laughing.

MR: Wow. I wish we had a drum to go "titi-boom."

JW: Yeah, titi-boom.

MR: I heard you also got a little baseball in in your career. You were with a pit band?

JW: Yeah. All the theaters, there was a fellow named John Ephrat, and he conceived the idea of starting a Broadway softball league, and all the theaters would have a ball team and they would compete with each other. And this meant that anybody in the cast or the stage hands could be a member of the team, which produced some pretty shabby ball teams.

There were some of them that were pretty good but most of them were pretty low key. And I was with "Silk Stockings," the Cole Porter show. And we won the championship that year. And I played ball when I was a kid, we played ball, had a neighborhood ball team. And my dad and my two uncles, my father's two brothers were very good ball players. We played baseball. So I had started out a long time ago playing ball and I enjoyed it, and we had a lot of fun out there. It was fun.

MR: What's your position of choice?

JW: I played shortstop or third base. I was never a long ball hitter but I could place hit pretty well. And when we won the championship, Mel Allen came and gave us — we got trophies for different things that we had done. It was very nice.

MR: How has the work scene changed for you, like in the last ten years? Do you pick and choose a little more than usual?

JW: I think you're almost right on that. I think I'm picked and chosen on occasion. I sometimes have the privilege of deciding what I want to do, but the offers are not that numerous now. And you know the other thing is I'm much older and I started out as a young player and some of the older fellows were moved out to make room for me, and so it's the same thing now. It's something you have to accept and understand. Because as you get older there are a lot of things that I find — like playing with the Smithsonian Orchestra — I do them but I don't do them with the ease that I did when I was younger. It really calls for a lot more concentration and a lot more practice. So I accept that. But I still can't complain because I still get a lot of nice things, and most of them, with regard to picking and choosing, I do decide if I'm not going to enjoy doing it I won't do it. I'm too old to be hassled by what I have to do.

MR: I wanted to play a piece and talk about improvising if we could. "No Greater Love."

[audio interlude]

MR: First of all it sounds like two trumpet players.

JW: That's exactly what I had in mind, too. It's like a put on but you know, you're kidding with yourself, like it's two different guys.

MR: What kind of mute was that?

JW: It's a plunger.

MR: Yeah.

JW: It's a toilet plunger, and it has a hole in the end. It has a hole in it so as you push it tight against the bell it sounds like a Harmon mute, that's why the lighter sounds. It sounds almost like a Harmon mute. That's why I could get away with that.

MR: This is actually a hard question to ask and answer, because improvising is something that is rather hard to define. But actually a student yesterday was asking you I think the same

question, about your thought process when you're improvising. Is it possible to verbalize what you think about on any particular tune while you're playing?

JW: Well I don't know. These things come to you automatically. I mean sometimes, usually if I'm going to play something while someone else is playing, I'll try to think of something that I would like to start, introduce my solo with, and it's something that's relative to the nature of the piece itself, and something that fits kind of harmonically with what's going on. And I usually try to think about that. And I also think it's just — improvisation it's like giving a speech or something like that. You have a subject, and your interpretation of it may differ from mine, but it's still basically the same subject so that's a theme that you're improvising around. And you try to play something that enhances it, and also adds a little different flavor to it. So you don't come in and play exactly what the person before you. You may even extract some of what he played as a lead in to what you're going to do, so you get that dove-tailing, and it's like passing the baton in a relay race. You do it smoothly. You don't do this — you're running and you pick up the same speed as that person whom you're going to accept the baton from or pass it to, and you get that smooth transition you know. That's — if you listen to a lot of improvisation in different groups, when they have that smooth transfer from one to the other, that's the way it does. That's the way it comes off.

MR: Yeah. I like that analogy. If you took any particular standard that you feel comfortably playing with, do you have those sequence of chords memorized in your head?

JW: Sometimes.

MR: But not always?

JW: Not always.

MR: But you can still negotiate your way through it?

JW: Right. There are some pieces that are a little difficult to come up with something when you're improvising. It's kind of hard to think of something that works pretty well. So sometimes you'll have something in your head that you knew worked once before, and you use that as a platform to start off from. I was just trying to think of something. I'll think of some tune in particular.

MR: Well I know just before I turned this tape off that when you got to the bridge of the song you started playing [scats] until maybe you thought of something else. I mean that's the assumption on my part.

JW: Right.

MR: But there's nothing wrong with playing a bit of the melody in your improvising.

JW: No, not at all. So at least we know where we're coming from with it.

MR: I usually pretend my saxophone is broken if I can't think of anything. That's something that works. I had made a little note about something I read and I wonder if it actually

happened. This came out of one of those anecdote books. Are you familiar with a fellow named John Frosk?

JW: Oh, Johnny Frosk.

MR: And there was some incident — Glenn Osser was conducting something for Cyd Charisse or something, and apparently he called "In the Mood."

JW: Oh, yeah.

MR: Was this a true — did this really happen?

JW: About Johnny Frosk?

MR: Yeah.

JW: Absolutely.

MR: And his trumpet solo? Can you tell me how that happened?

JW: We were doing "Juke Box Saturday Night." It was a series they had on channel 13. And when the trumpet solo came on, Johnny Frosk stood up and played "In the Mood" or something. The solo he played was note for note from some other piece. It had nothing to do with this harmonically or otherwise. And he just played it. And Abe Osser was standing and looking, he couldn't believe that this was happening, with a straight face. It was unbelievable.

MR: Was it "String of Pearls" or something?

JW: That's what it was.

MR: Because I know that they're both the same length. That's so funny.

JW: You'd have to know Johnny Frosk to know. He's a wonderful first trumpet player by the way.

MR: Here's another hard question. Can you recall some of the most difficult playing situations you've been in, just from a trumpet standpoint? And did you get through them successfully?

JW: A couple of times when I played with the Philharmonic, and it wasn't difficult but I found it to be a little stressful because here you're somebody who is not really generally playing in that idiom and now you're in the middle of it and you've got to perform like everybody else, and I found that a little tensing. But it's rewarding of course to do it, and I was very flattered, because how often does anybody who's supposed to be a commercial or a jazz player get an opportunity to do something like that. It was totally unrelated to the other things that I'd been accustomed to doing. But then there've been some other situations, I did the Haydn "Trumpet Concerto" a few times with the Municipal Concerts Orchestra in New York. And I did it with the ABC Symphony once. And in doing some of those things of course you can't help but feel a little tension. But again, it's challenging and once having done it, it's very rewarding.

MR: The definition of a mistake is much clearer in that music.

JW: Right.

MR: I mean I noticed a few times in the Fallcoming concert we just heard, which was great, that there was a few times that I think the soloist may have gone in a direction that they didn't really intend, but you're able to —

JW: You're able to get around that.

MR: Get around it and get out of it, and it sounded like you meant to do it, whether or not you did.

JW: Right. That's when your faculties come into focus, and again trying to — you create something that you didn't intend to create. And it comes off, very often.

MR: Now you got a bachelor's from Manhattan School of Music.

JW: Manhattan School of Music, yeah.

MR: The process of learning how to function in a combo for instance, the jazz etiquette and so forth, did you get any of that there or how do you learn that?

JW: You mean going from the jazz to the classical?

MR: Yes. I mean how did you learn to play in a small combo? Was it simply by doing it?

JW: Basically that's what it was, yeah. In Philadelphia I played with a small group, Lonnie Slappey's band, and there was a trumpet player, Frank Galbraith, who was really an exceptional — he had a different style from almost anybody else that I had heard. And he sort of established the style of this group. But it was predicated more or less on the John Kirby Band, because the make-up of the band was basically the same. But it was a different style band. And I took his place, and I was still in school at the time. So from listening to him and the things he did, I began trying to do some things of mine that were not necessarily anywhere near the kinds of things he did, but I would get an opportunity to experiment, and some things worked and those things I retained, and the others I let go, but it was a chance for me to practice all the time and get that experience. It's a little different playing in a small group. It's like playing in a brass quintet and chamber orchestras you know. There's more exposed playing. It calls for a little more technique very often because you're not buried in a section with an orchestra of 60 or 70 people or something like that. And everything you do someone can focus on so you develop a little more technique and more daring.

MR: Is it harder for the trumpet player to play in quintets and sextets because the trumpet man usually is responsible for the melody?

JW: They are. But everyone is sort of — this is where you're more or less, everyone is treated equally by the composers and the music you're playing. Because in quintets, regardless of what chair you're playing, your chair is very important. And at some point you're playing solo, you're playing solo parts. It's very interesting, and you develop a sense of relationship musically to the other players you're playing with in the group.

MR: How is the actual business — it seems that there are too many stories about business people taking advantage of musicians over the years. Have you experienced that and has it changed?

JW: Well I think it's changed and for instance, as in the case of the jazz party you have here at Hamilton, especially with people like Milt Fillius. I mean these are men who are proud of who they are and they want people who work for them to feel proud of having been associated with him. I'm using him as an example. There are a few others, there aren't many, but there are some others who think likewise. And they treat the musicians very well, with a great deal of respect, and of course they expect the same in return. But they're the exceptions. There are a lot of people who still think, for instance I was called to do a recording with Maxine Sullivan which turned out to be her last recording, and I would gladly have done it for nothing basically. But the fellow who called me, when he called me and said that she had asked if I could do a recording with her, and I said I'd be flattered to do it. I said, "by the way, how much are you paying?" And he said, "hey, Joe, we pay sideman scale." And I won't mention his name. I said, "well you've got it." Boom and I just hung up on him. Now these are guys who still think it's the 20's and the 30's and musicians are struggling as they did during that period and would accept almost anything, whatever you offered you know, and you dictate the terms not they you know.

MR: Well especially the attitude, too.

JW: Yeah. You had a lot of that. And you would go work in clubs and things and they would pay the guys a pittance. They were making good money but they wouldn't give it to them. Well Lionel Hampton was a good case in point. I joined that band and I was making eleven dollars a night, and I was playing, at that time, the first trumpet part. I wasn't playing the high things, he had guys there, Ernie Royal and guys who did that. But I was supposed to be the first trumpet player and I was getting eleven dollars a night, and I asked him at one point when I discovered that the other guys, some of them, were getting fifteen, I thought well why can't I get fifteen too? And I asked him about it and he said, "well you'd better speak to Gladys" his wife. And he said, "she takes care of that." So I spoke to her and she said, "yes what is it, young man?" And I said, "well I'd like to get fifteen dollars a night like everybody else." She said, "well honey you better talk to Joe Glaser" who was the manager. And so I called his office and made an appointment to see him. And a couple days hence I went to his office, at the time, two o'clock like he says. And when I walked in his secretary said, "who are you?" And I said, "well my name is Joe Wilder, and Mrs. Hampton told me to come and see Mr. Glaser, and I made an appointment for two o'clock." And she said okay. She called him on the intercom and he said okay send him in. And when I went in he said, "what do you want?" And I said "well Mrs. Hampton told me to come and speak to you about getting a raise." He said,

"hey" — if you will excuse the language — "who in the hell do you think you are?" This was exactly the way he asked me. And I looked at him and I said, "who in the hell do you think YOU are?" And I turned around and walked out and that night I told Lionel, I said, "if I don't get fifteen dollars a night from tonight on, I'm out, you'll have to get somebody else." And so he said, "well I'll talk to Gladys about it." So he spoke to her and as of the next night they did pay me fifteen dollars a night. But that was the attitude towards the musicians and unfortunately I mean in some places it still prevails.

MR: And probably some other musicians would have not pursued it like you did.

JW: No, well they might have been intimidated by it, not that I wasn't too, I mean to some extent I was. I mean I'm a young kid. But that's the way it went.

MR: If you were on the road for eleven dollars a night, you had to buy your own meals out of that.

JW: You could get by on that, but you were also playing your room rent out of that. And it was almost like in a sense I guess you could say we were like slave labor you know, slave wages. And they were making a fortune, I mean really making a fortune. You couldn't get into the halls where they were playing, they were so popular. It was a good band, a young band. Well as I say, that's the way it went.

MR: I guess it makes you appreciate, to pay those kind of dues makes the good times that much better.

JW: That's true too in a sense. And it also makes you aware of treating other people fairly yourself. And if you ever find yourself in that position, the first thing I think about is treating the other guys the same way. I've done recordings and things like that, or I did something for Schaefer Beer, oh I guess a couple of years ago, and I was the leader of this particular group. And so rather than take — they say we'll pay you a certain amount of money. This was through the Peter Duchin office. And I accepted it, I said okay. And it was just a quartet. And so I just took the money and split it up, and we all got the same thing. You know I said it's no big deal, we just all get the same thing. But that's the way I tried to do it, and it's the way I feel about it, but it comes from the treatment that I got as a young musician.

MR: It's a good lesson. I remember you talking a little bit about some fellows who would try to cut corners and play the game of booking two sessions at the same time too, and that kind of —

JW: These were guys who were counting every penny they could get. And someone would call you for a jingle date, a commercial, a television commercial or something. And they would say well can you do a date from ten 'till twelve. And the guy would say yes. And then someone else would call, maybe shortly thereafter, and say this date would be in the next week. And someone else would call and say "yeah, I've got a date that goes from

twelve o'clock until three, can you make it?" Now he's got a date from ten 'till twelve, and he's like fifteen blocks away from the other studio. It's no way he's going to get to the other gig on time. And so the guy would say yes to the fellow. Instead of saying I won't be able to make it because I'm already busy, he'd say yes to the guy that has the twelve to three date, and show up on his date at maybe a quarter to one, and say jeez, you know I didn't know that the other date was going to go overtime or something, not calling to warn him of it or anything, just to make the money, rather than saying let somebody else make it. There's enough for all of us, and there was at that time, a lot. Sometimes we did three or four jingle dates on the same day. And it got to the point where, in my case, I wouldn't accept more than three. Now this doesn't mean like it was land office business or anything, but I wouldn't accept more than three because sometimes you'd go on one and it would be so easy to do that you felt like you were robbing them, and then by the time you got to the fourth one it would be something so hard that you wish you hadn't started playing the instrument, you know? That much of a difference. So I knew that I could handle three in one day, but four was rough.

MR: Was there certain arrangers whose names that you liked to see on the chart, and certain that you didn't?

JW: Oh yeah. Neal Hefti was one of them. Neal Hefti, now because you asked me that I can't think of some, but there were several guys who you just broke your neck getting to the studio to work for them because it was always, always a joy. Billy Byers, guys like that, Kent Hopkins. These guys could write and Buddy Weed was another one, Glenn Osser, who was the conductor of the Miss America pageant. Like when we did the Miss America pageant it was always a joy because he wrote such beautiful arrangements. Everything was just perfect you know. And you got such a big kick out of playing that music. And Neal Hefti was a guy, anytime I got a call and it said it's for Neal, I said I'll be there.

MR: What do you think of the state of music these days? How's that for an open question?

JW: No, not really. It's strange and there are a lot of things that of course the younger musicians have different ideas about how the music should be played and the kind of music. And I don't condemn them for it, I guess because of the era in which I grew up, I don't relate to it too well, but I remember a time when I thought The Beatles were terrible when they first — I thought it was some of the worst garbage I'd ever heard. But as I began hearing more and more of it I began to acquire a great respect for what they were doing, and a lot of what they did was tremendous and has influenced a lot of the things that we do today and that are acceptable. So I won't put down any of the young people, the young guys with the rock, or what do they call it, "third stream" and —

MR: Fusion.

JW: Fusion and those things. I mean it's just another aspect of music. And I'm sure that as time goes on there'll be other developments that come along. But from those there will be a lot of well established styles that will be accepted.

MR: Do you recall if your parents listened to the music that you liked and how did they feel about it? Did they feel that —

JW: My father, being a musician, is the one that pointed me I guess in the right direction, and my mother too for that matter. But my father used to listen, we had the radio and that's all you had, and you listened to the old bands, some of which people wonder where I'm coming from with this, but there were bands like Gus Anheim, Paul Whiteman of course and Duke Ellington was one of my father's favorites, and there was Cab Calloway and Fletcher Henderson and all these different bands, and then we used to listen to Horace Heidt and those bands, and we listened to every band because they were playing all the time. Any time you turned on the radio, day or night, you could hear some of these orchestras. My father listened to them intently. And so I came up listening to all these things, and without having someone point it out to me I just acquired an appreciation for all the different styles that I heard. And my father was even a fan of the [scats] Wayne King and Guy Lombardo.

MR: Yeah. He even liked the syrupy stuff.

JW: He liked all these and so through him I learned to appreciate all of these bands. You could identify them because their styles were so different.

MR: You must look at your career and be pretty happy.

JW: Yeah, I am. I've been one of the most fortunate musicians I guess in the country. Most of the things I did I did with people I enjoyed doing them with. Most of the music I was involved with I got great enjoyment out of, and I still do. Like the guys who we were here with the other night. I mean how can you go someplace, as an employee, and have that much fun? It's unreal.

MR: Where is the state of — I'm not sure how to ask this question, but over the years, has the way the business been set up provided you with some kind of retirement? For twenty years from now when you stop playing.

JW: Well I get a pension from the Federation, the American Federation of Musicians. And having worked in the theater and done those jobs from which money was extracted for your pension, I'm in pretty good shape. Unfortunately when you look back and you look at Duke Ellington's band, Woody Herman's band, Count Basie's band, those fellas had absolutely nothing going into a pension fund. They had nothing going in there, so that when they finished playing, it was like if they hadn't saved any money on their own, that was it. When the earning thing stopped, that was the end of their ability to earn money, there was nothing left. And of course when you're on the road with a band, and especially

when you're younger, we all had the idea that this goes on forever. I mean you never look into the future, you don't think that way, you have no reason to. But I'm one of the fortunate guys, really.

MR: Have you seen or heard anything about the swing revival that supposedly is happening these days? The swing revival.

JW: Oh I think that's coming about. Because when I would play some of the jazz parties you'd see people who were in my age group and some a little younger. But now with the Smithsonian Orchestra for example and the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra and the Carnegie Hall Band, when they go out, a lot of young people are coming. Of course they're coming, a lot of them, because there are young people in those bands. But at the same time the music they're listening to is the music from the swing era. And they're being educated in that regard, and you're developing a following, a new following of that. Because there's been a whole hiatus from jazz of the swing era for a long time, mainly because people don't go to ballrooms anymore. What they hear mostly I guess they hear on television and things like that. But now they're coming out. It's a good sign.

MR: Yeah. Did you have occasion to play the Savoy?

JW: The Savoy Ballroom, oh yeah, I played the Savoy Ballroom with Lucky Millinder, I played in there with Jimmy Lunceford's band, I subbed in there a few times with Erskine Hawkins band, Jimmy Rushing had a band, I played with them a few times, I played a lot at the Savoy Ballroom. That was quite a place.

MR: I just wish I could have been there. It sounds like a great scene.

JW: Yeah, that was something. There were certain tempos that would get people going, they wanted to dance to, certain tempos. And Lucky Millinder was one of the guys that knew exactly what tempos and certain pieces that people would like to dance to. And he'd get these things, like they'd do the "Huckle Buck" [scats]. And you'd look out there and people would be getting up out of their seats and going out on the dance floor. And the floor had a certain spring to it, and when it would be full you could just see the floor floating up just a little bit. I don't know if they had some coasters or something under it, but to keep the vibration, to carry the vibration of this continual dancing and everything, it was something to see, I mean just a sea of people, all up there. Funny scenes out there.

MR: It has a positive effect on the music.

JW: Yeah. It was the music. They had the Savoy Sultans, that was a little group, and they used to play in there and big bands would come in, and these bands would be good, but the Savoy Sultans knew the tempos that got everybody's heart started. And sometimes a big band would be in there and they would almost die, and the Sultans would come in and just tear up the house you know, because of the tempos they played in.

MR: Who was in the original Sultans?

JW: The Savoy Sultans?

MR: Yeah. Can you recall? I'm trying to remember. I know Panama Francis was in there years later.

JW: Now I can't remember, what was his name. Because the leader's name, it was like so-and-so and the Savoy Sultans. I can't remember his name.

MR: Well we'll get out the history book later and check it out.

JW: Yeah.

MR: What do you have coming up in the future?

JW: Well the Smithsonian has a big tour coming up in January. And actually when I go back now I may have a couple of things, but I'm going to really take it easy because I'm still having a lot of dental work done, and this will give me a chance to take care of it and give me a chance to recuperate from it. So probably from now until the beginning of January I won't do much, if anything at all.

MR: Who do you hear, young jazz trumpeters these days, that appeal to you?

JW: I think most of them do, and unfortunately I can't remember all their names off the top of my head, but these guys, some of them, they're so talented. And they can do many things. They can play jazz, they can play classical, and they've got range and ideas and technique. It's just phenomenal. But they've had training at an earlier age than most of us did, and they're able to apply it. They're good players.

MR: Is there one band or orchestra or circumstance that you missed that you could go back to if you could turn back the clock?

JW: I guess, well you know I loved Basie's band. The Count was so relaxed and so nice, he was a nice man, and the band was such a swinging band. I didn't stay with them long, I wasn't with them very long, but I enjoyed all the time that I was with them. And Jimmy Lunceford's band, I was so sorry that he passed away because the band was coming back and the guys he had in the band were good players and it was reaching a point where the band was really beginning to develop on the same level as the original band, which was very nice. But Jimmy died and that was the end of that. But Sam Donahue certainly had a good band. Most of the bands that I played with were enjoyable to play with, and I just more or less went from one thing to the other as a matter of security, because when I left the road and tried working in New York, I started doing Broadway shows. But I first went to the Diamond Horeshoe with Noble Sissle, I was working in the Diamond Horeshoe with Noble Sissle when I got called to do a show called "Alive and Kicking." That was the first Broadway show I did, and that was with Carl Reiner, Jack Guilford and I forget, there was another comedian who was very well known. And those guys, they were in the show. Carl Reiner was writing for the show and everything. And it lasted seven weeks. And while I was in the Diamond Horeshoe and I got called, I had to ask

Noble Sissle if I could get out to go do this, because you were required to give two weeks notice to the employer you were working for, and they were getting the show together in less than the two weeks. So I asked him and he said, "well you know there are no black musicians playing in the Broadway theater, and maybe this will be a nice chance to get started." So he said, "okay young man you can go," he said, "I'll give you five weeks" or something like that. "And after that I have to get somebody to replace you." So I thought that was fair. And the show closed after seven, but he still let me come back. And shortly thereafter I got another call to do another show that turned out to be "Guys and Dolls." And so he said, "well now I'm going to do the same thing. After five weeks, if you're not back I have to get someone else." And that show went three years. So I was lucky. But it was thanks to him that I got the chance to do it.

MR: That first show you did, that must have been quite a switch.

JW: It was. It was a revue too, by the way. It wasn't a show with a format like "Guys and Dolls" or something like that. And they kept changing the material. Every day they would change. They went seven weeks, but for seven weeks of complete changing all the time, and it never did meld together too well, that's why it failed. It was an interesting experience really.

MR: Wow, and then you did one show for three years.

JW: "Guys and Dolls." And that was considered a long run, three years. And then when we got around I did "Silk Stockings" and "A Most Happy Fella," and then during "A Most Happy Fella," before that was over I went on staff at ABC. But those were good shows.

MR: Well it's been fascinating talking to you again.

JW: Well you certainly put me at ease.

MR: Anything that I haven't asked you that you'd like to —

JW: Well I think we've covered quite a bit. When we get off we'll probably think of a hundred other things that we might have touched on.

MR: But I do think you should go home and listen to some of your own recordings.

JW: I guess you've got a point there. I have some of them like this that are still in the cellophane. In fact, what recording was it, oh I did a classical album, Alec Wilder wrote a sonata for me. He had a knack of writing concerti and sonatas and things for his friends you know. And he really puts you to the test. So I recorded a thing, and I had forgotten who had written the liner notes mainly because I just glanced at them when the album came out. And it was Jim Marr had written the liner notes and we were over at Rutgers University and we were on the way home and he was talking about this album because they had played some excerpts of it, Ed Berger had played some of it. And he was saying yeah, you know such-and-such a thing about it. And he said, "when I wrote the liner

notes — I was embarrassed. And when I got home I looked — I didn't even realize it was Jim Marr who had written the liner notes. I didn't tell him.

MR: That you hadn't even read them. Unbelievable.

JW: But it was because I hadn't played the album. Then I listened to it.

MR: I think most musicians when they listen to their own work, they probably say —

JW: We listen to it in the studio when we're doing the final thing, sometimes before it's even been mastered, and you listen to it, and usually, in my case I'll hear something that I say well that wasn't really right, and I wish I hadn't done this that way or something like that. Not that this would have been any better or worse, but you listen and I'm very critical about that. I mean I hear things that I know could have been done better. And that disturbs me so I don't bother to listen to it.

MR: Well I like them. All right well we'll wrap up and thanks for your time again.

JW: Oh you're certainly welcome, Monk. Thank you so much.

MR: Thanks a lot.